

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

CV Screening Scorecard

Screen applications consistently and bias-aware against the role, so the same evidence gets the same score every time.

Purpose

A CV screening scorecard replaces "this one feels strong" with a repeatable rating against the criteria in your job description. It exists to make shortlisting consistent, defensible and fairer — the same CV should score the same regardless of who reads it or which day they read it.

When to use it

- At the sift stage, before any interview, to decide who progresses.
- Whenever more than one person is screening — the scorecard is what keeps them calibrated.
- For any role where you want a defensible, evidence-based shortlist.

Instructions

1. Take your criteria straight from the JD's essential and desirable lists — do not invent new ones at the sift.
2. Weight the criteria by how much they matter for this role.
3. Score each on evidence in the CV using the 0-3 anchors below; write the evidence, not just the number.
4. Where your process allows, screen with name, photo, age, university and other bias-triggers redacted or ignored — focus on demonstrated skills.
5. Set a progression threshold before you start reading, so the bar is not moved to fit a favourite.
6. Keep your notes factual and retain them per your data-retention policy.

Scoring anchors (0-3)

Score	Meaning
0	No evidence in the CV.
1	Weak/indirect evidence — mentioned but not demonstrated.
2	Clear evidence of doing it.
3	Strong evidence of leading/owning it, with outcomes.

Worked example

The three candidates for Northstar's Senior QA Engineer (Automation & CD) role, screened against the JD. Candidate A is a deep automation/SDET specialist; Candidate B is a strong all-round senior tester with fintech domain and leadership but limited automation; Candidate C is a mid-level generalist with good API and CI exposure and strong learning signals.

Criterion (weight)	Cand A	Cand B	Cand C	Evidence note
Test automation — essential (x3)	3	1	2	A: re-architected a large flaky suite. B: automation only mentioned. C: built UI/API tests on a smaller product.
API / contract testing (x2)	2	2	3	C: contract testing named explicitly with outcomes.
CI/CD pipeline (x2)	3	1	2	A: owned pipeline and gates. B: little evidence. C: worked within one.
Coaching / spreading ownership (x2)	1	3	2	B: led and mentored a team. A: strong solo, thin on teaching. C: some pairing.
Communication with non-engineers (x1)	1	3	2	B: stakeholder-facing roles. A: little evidence.
Domain (fintech/payments) — desirable (x1)	1	3	1	B: years in payments.
Weighted total (max 33)	25	21	25	A and C tie; B trails on the essentials but leads on people/domain.

Screening read: A and C both clear the bar on the essentials and are worth interviewing; B is strong but weakest on the automation the role is built around — progress B only if you are prepared to reconsider what the role is really for. The scorecard has done its job: it has produced a defensible shortlist, not a winner. The winner is decided later, with more evidence.

HR AND LEGAL NOTE

This is a decision-support tool, not legal advice. Always run your process through your own HR/People team and follow local employment law on data handling, right-to-work, records retention, reasonable adjustments and non-discrimination. Ask every candidate for a role the same questions against the same criteria, record the evidence rather than the impression, and keep your notes factual — they may be disclosable.

How to interpret the results

- The score ranks, it does not decide. Use it to choose who to interview, then gather better evidence live.
- A low score on an essential criterion is a harder stop than a high total — a strong average can hide a fatal gap in the one thing the role needs.
- A CV screens for what someone has written down, which favours confident self-promoters. Treat a modest CV with the right skills as worth a call, not an automatic reject.
- If two screeners disagree by more than one point on a criterion, recalibrate the anchors before continuing.

Blank reusable version

Criterion (weight)	Cand 1	Cand 2	Cand 3	Evidence note
Weighted total				

Anchors: 0 none · 1 weak/indirect · 2 clear evidence · 3 strong, with outcomes. Set your progression threshold before reading.

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Scoring on a vibe and back-filling the numbers. Inventing criteria at the sift that were never in the JD.
 Letting name, university, career gaps or a non-native writing style sway the score — all classic bias traps.
 Moving the threshold to admit someone you liked. Rewarding CV-writing skill over actual capability.
 Screening solo on a contentious role when a second calibrated reader would have caught your blind spot.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Decide your progression threshold and weightings before you open a single CV. The moment you set the bar after seeing the applicants, you are no longer screening candidates — you are rationalising the ones you already fancied.